

Participant Instructions

Project Title: Learning English as a second language in Chinese international students: The role of pre-task planning on second language writing performance (Project ID Number: 29617)

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These instructions aim to standardise the pre-task planning and formal writing processes for participants in the "individual planning" condition. All participants in this condition will be informed of the contents of these instructions before the task begins and will be asked to provide informed consent to comply with them; participants may decide at their own discretion whether to continue participating in the task.

Under this condition, you will be given 10 minutes prior to the formal writing stage to plan your essay. During the planning stage, you must not write complete paragraphs, nor are you permitted to consult any external resources. You may finish planning early and proceed to the writing stage; once writing begins, you will have 30 minutes to complete an assigned English argumentative essay of 200–250 words. During the writing process, no external resources or assistive tools may be used. You may finish and submit your task early at any time.

In the event of any discrepancy between the Chinese and English versions of this document, the English version shall prevail; the Chinese version is provided for reference only.

Guidelines and Rules for the Planning and Writing Task

(1) In the pre-writing planning stage, enter your assigned Subject code and Topic code, then click "Continue". Once you are ready, click "Start Task". The topic will be displayed, and the planning timer will begin. After the timer starts, you will have 10 minutes to plan your essay. You may take notes on the blank scratch paper provided.

(2) Regarding the planning stage, you may independently engage in the following activities, including but not limited to:

- ✓ Independently generating possible arguments;
- ✓ Considering different perspectives;
- ✓ Considering reasons or examples for relevant arguments;
- ✓ Organising the structure of the essay;
- ✓ Brainstorming useful vocabulary, collocations, and/or short expressions;
- ✓ Planning in any language (e.g., English, Chinese).

(3) Regarding the planning stage, the following planning methods are NOT permitted in this study:

- × Using AI;
- × Consulting words, collocations, sentences, or sample essays in any way, including but not limited to dictionaries, online searches, or essay guidebooks;
- × Writing the complete essay, or any paragraphs of the essay, during the planning stage.

Once your preparation is complete, you can click "Finish Planning Early" to proceed to the formal writing timer. This action cannot be undone.

(4) Formal Writing Stage: After the planning time ends, you will enter the formal writing task. You have 30 minutes to complete an English argumentative essay on the assigned topic, containing no fewer than 200 words (and no more than 250 words). During the writing process, you may still view the planning notes or outlines written during the planning stage, but you must not use any external resources or assistive tools, including but not limited to:

- × AI;
- × Online searches;
- × Dictionaries or translation tools;
- × Sample essays or other reference materials;
- × Writing assistants such as Grammarly, Microsoft Editor, or LanguageTool.

(5) Finishing Early: If you complete the essay before the 30 minutes are up, you may click "Finish" to end the task early. Then, click "Download Data Package (.zip)" and send the data package (ZIP file) to the researcher.

(6) Regarding your planning and writing logs: To study the planning and writing process, your scratch paper from the planning stage, the text produced during the formal writing stage, your revision process, and related writing logs will be saved for subsequent research analysis. These records will be used solely for research purposes and will be archived and handled in strict accordance with the relevant ethical requirements of the University of Melbourne, as detailed in the Consent Form.

IMPORTANT: Please ensure you have read and understood these rules before the task officially begins. Before participating in this study, you are also required to sign the Consent Form and read the Plain Language Statement provided by the researcher. If you have any other questions regarding this study, please seek further clarification or assistance from the researcher.